Denglisch

The influence of English on German — better or worse?

Global English · English as Europe’s lingua franca

Max Aulinger · [name] · [name] · [name]

A NORMAL GERMAN SENTENCE

You don’t speak German.
How many words do you understand?

Heute habe ich ein Meeting mit meinem Team. Danach checke ich meine E-Mails, downloade die Files und gehe shoppen. Mein Handy ist fast leer.

“Today I have a meeting with my team. Then I check my emails, download the files and go shopping. My phone is almost dead.”

8 English words in three short sentences — and one of them isn’t even real English.

DENGLISCH IN REAL LIFE

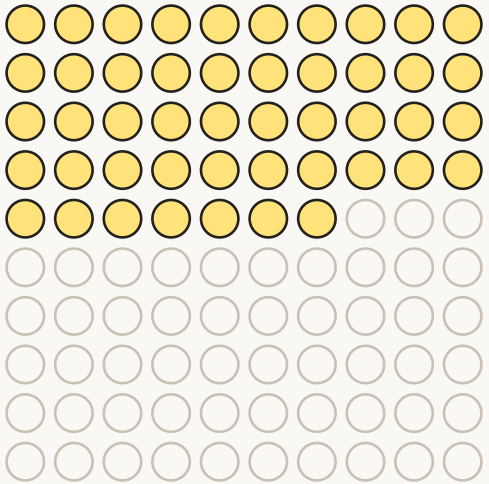
How young Germans actually talk

Das ist so cringe.	*That's so cringe.*
Ich bin komplett lost.	*I'm totally lost.*
Actually hab ich keine Zeit.	*Actually, I don't have time.*
Das war so random.	*That was so random.*
Literally jeder war da.	*Literally everyone was there.*
— Ich hab keinen Bock. — Same.	*"I can't be bothered." "Same."*

No translation, no new meaning — just English words dropped into a German sentence.

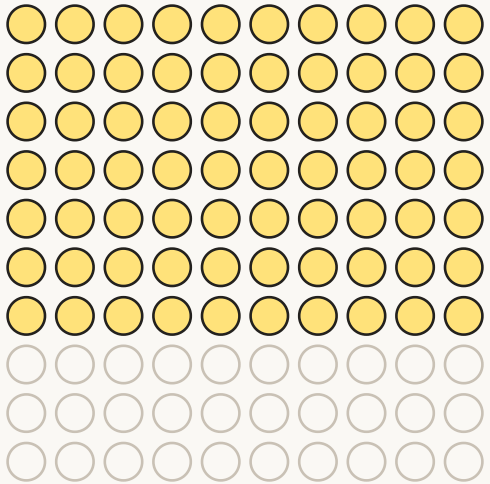
Almost every second European speaks English.

When a German, a Spaniard and a Pole meet, they speak English.



47 of 100

people in the EU can have a conversation in English



70 of 100

young Europeans — and that’s exactly where Denglisch comes from

European Commission, Eurobarometer “Europeans and their languages” (2024).

WHAT DENGLISCH IS

Three ways English gets into German

1

Taken as it is

das Meeting

das Team

der Job

das Feedback

Same word — it just gets a German article: **der, die, das**.

2

English word, German grammar

downloaden

chillen

googeln

liken

ich habe gechillt — “I chilled”. English inside, German outside.

3

Fake English

das Handy

der Beamer

das Public Viewing

Looks English. **No English speaker** uses it like that.

JUGENDWORT DES JAHRES

Germany’s Youth Word of the Year

2008 – 2018 · CHOSEN BY A JURY

Gammelfleischparty 2008
hartzen 2009
Niveaulimbo 2010
Swag 2011
YOLO 2012
Babo 2013
Läuft bei dir 2014
Smombie 2015
fly sein 2016
I bims 2017
Ehrenmann 2018

4 of 11 English

SINCE 2020 · YOUNG PEOPLE VOTE THEMSELVES

lost 2020
cringe 2021
smash 2022
goofy 2023
Aura 2024
das crazy 2025
ragebait 2026

6 of 7 English

Since young people choose, almost every winner is English. 2025 even won “das crazy” — an English word with a German article.

yellow = English · dashed = from another language (Babo, Aura) · 2019: no winner. Source: Langenscheidt.

QUIZ · FAKE ENGLISH

These words look English.
But what do Germans mean by them?

Handy	**Beamer**	**Public Viewing**
Oldtimer	**Home Office**	**Smoking**

“Come in and find out.”

That was the English slogan of Douglas, a big German perfume shop.

In a 2003 study, many Germans understood it as: “Come in — and find your way back out.”

Not everyone in Germany speaks English. If people don’t understand it, Denglisch doesn’t bring people together — **it shuts them out.**

Words German already had

DENGLISCH	THE GERMAN WORD THAT WAS ALREADY THERE
Meeting	**Besprechung**
Feedback	**Rückmeldung**
Event	**Veranstaltung**
Sale	**Ausverkauf**
Deadline	**Abgabetermin**

These words don’t fill a gap. They replace German words that worked fine — often just because English sounds more modern.

Even Germans don’t know how to say it.

Ich habe die Datei _____ .

“I have ____ the file.” Which one is correct? Vote!

gedownloadet | **downgeloadet** | **downloadet**

The Duden dictionary says: downgeloadet. But in real German texts, about one in three people write **gedownloadet**.

Same problem everywhere: liken → geliked or gelikt? updaten → geupdatet or upgedatet?

THE CASE FOR

Sometimes English is simply the better word.

1

New things need names

Smartphone

Laptop

Podcast

Streaming

German never had **its own words** for these.

2

Short and international

Team

Job

online

okay

The same word works in Berlin, Paris **and Seoul.**

3

German makes it its own

Handyvertrag

Onlineshop

Teamleiter

gechillt

English parts, built into **German words and grammar.**

And it’s not new: *Balkon* and *Toilette* came from French 300 years ago.
Today nobody notices.

OUR ANSWER

Better or worse? Neither. It’s change.

WORSE WHEN …	BETTER WHEN …
it replaces a German word for no reason — *Meeting instead of Besprechung*	it names something new — *Computer, Internet, Smartphone*
people don’t understand it — *“come in and find out”*	it helps Germans talk to the rest of Europe
	Germans get creative with it — *Handy, Beamer*

German isn’t dying. It does what it always did: it takes words and makes them German.

YOUR TURN

Germany says Handy.
Korea says 핸드폰.

핸드폰 = *haen-deu-pon* = “hand phone”

Two countries, two made-up English words for the same thing. Neither one is used in the UK or the US.

So — is English making German better or worse? And what about Korean?

hands up → **better** · **worse** · **neither**

SOURCES

Where we got this from.

English in the EU — European Commission, Special Eurobarometer 540 “Europeans and their languages” (2024; survey autumn 2023, 26,523 people)

Youth Word of the Year — Jugendwort des Jahres, Langenscheidt, winners 2008–2026

“downgeloadet” — Duden online, conjugation of *downloaden*; usage in real texts from the DeReKo corpus, as reported by Neerlandistiek (2021)

“Come in and find out” — study on English advertising slogans by the agency Endmark (2003)